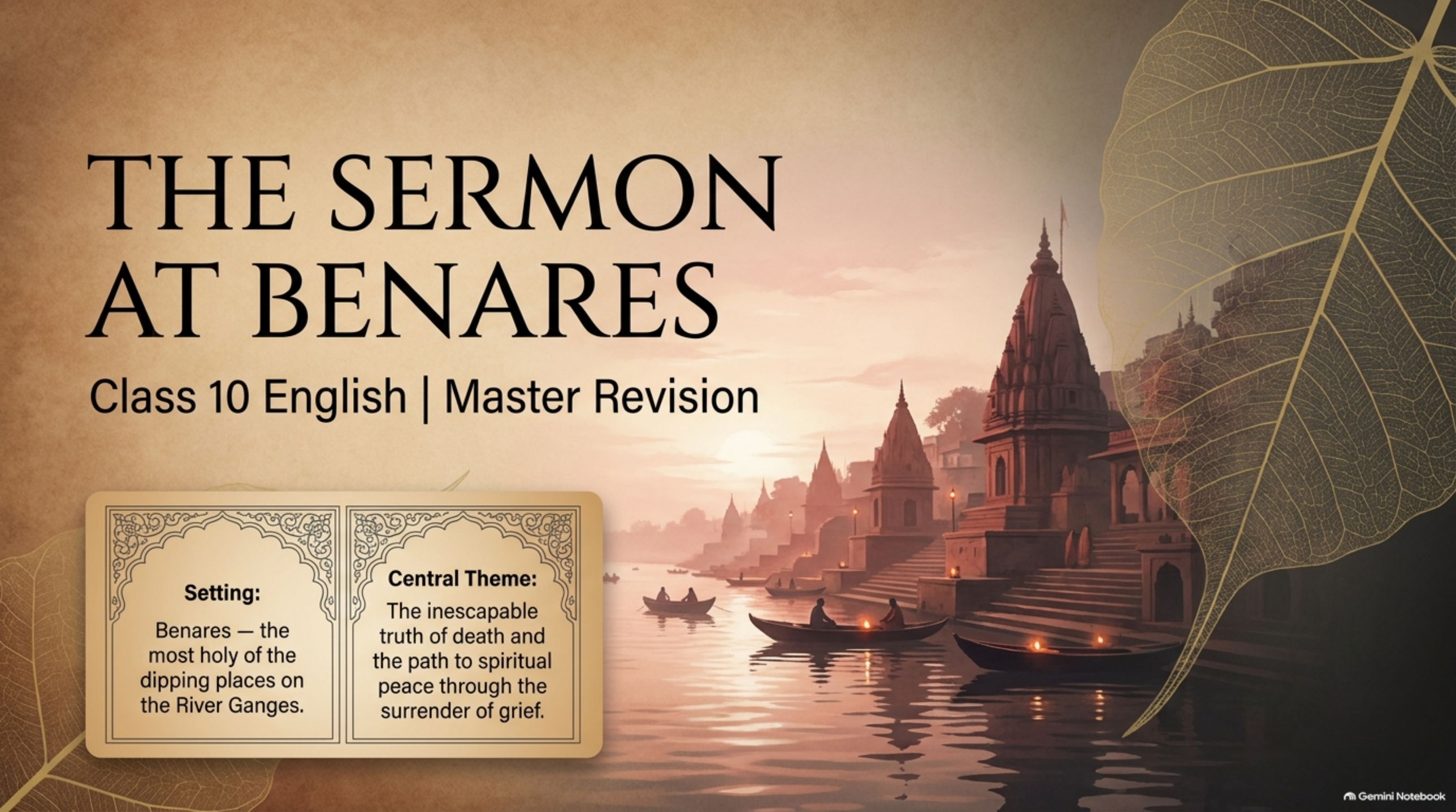
THE SERMON AT BENARES

Class 10 English | Master Revision



Setting:

Benares — the most holy of the dipping places on the River Ganges.

Central Theme:

The inescapable truth of death and the path to spiritual peace through the surrender of grief.

Gemini Notebook

The Shielded Prince

- **563 B.C. – 483 B.C.** | Born as Prince Siddhartha Gautama in northern India.
- **Age 12** | Sent away to study Hindu sacred scriptures.
- **Age 16** | Returned to marry a princess.
- **For 10 Years** | Lived happily, having a son, living as befitted royalty.

Key Insight: The Prince was completely shielded from the sufferings of the world.

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The Four Sights (Age 25)

A Sick Man
(Disease)

An Aged Man
(Decay)

A Funeral Procession
(Death)

A Monk begging for alms
(Asceticism)

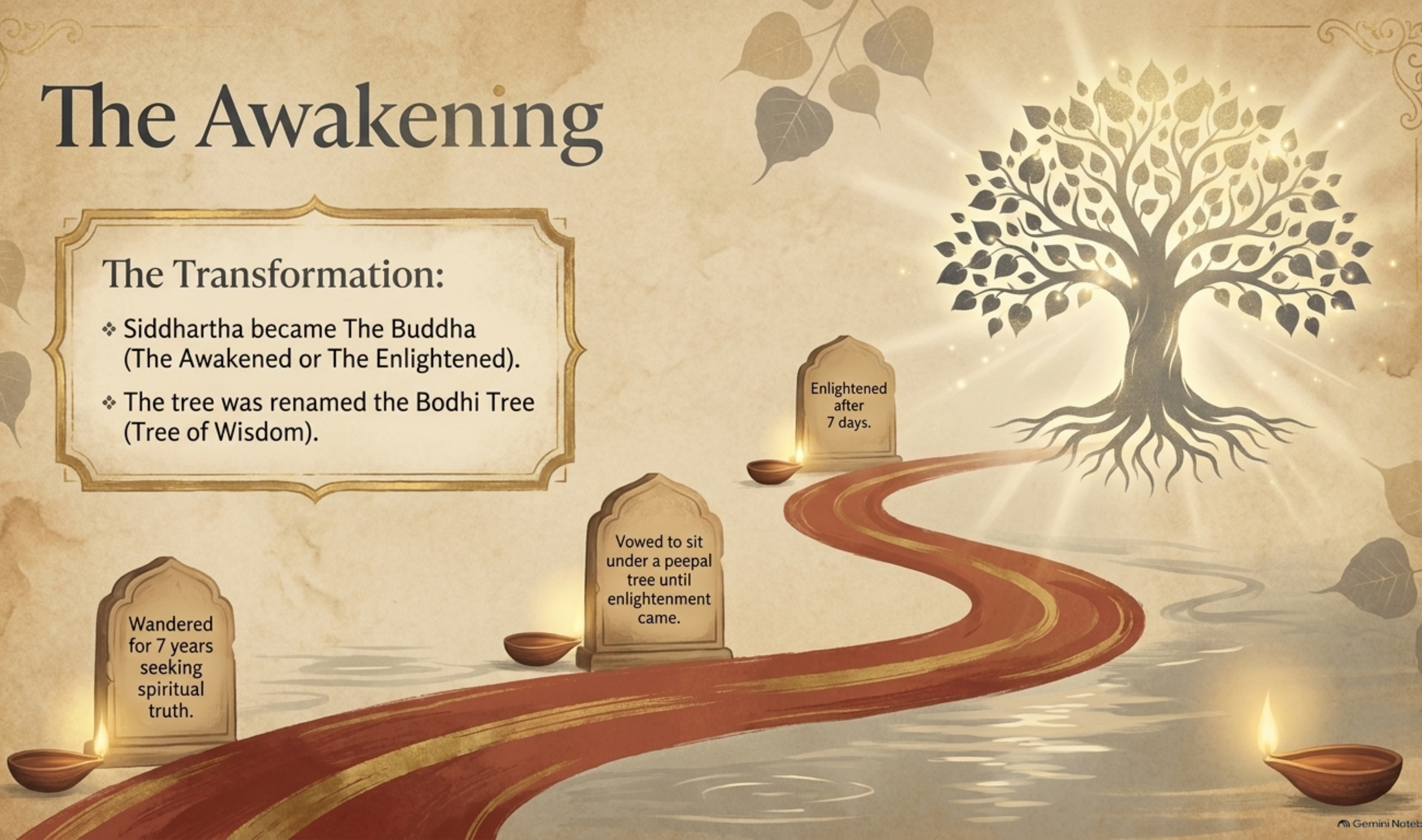
These sights moved him so deeply that he abandoned his royal life to seek enlightenment regarding the sorrows of the world.

Gemini Notebook

The Awakening

The Transformation:

- Siddhartha became The Buddha (The Awakened or The Enlightened).
- The tree was renamed the Bodhi Tree (Tree of Wisdom).



Gemini Notebook

The First Sermon

Where: The city of Benares, on the banks of the holy River Ganges.

Why Benares: Known as the most holy of the dipping places.

The Sermon's Purpose: To share his newly found wisdom about one inscrutable (impossible to understand) kind of suffering: Death.

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The Grief of Kisa Gotami

- **The Tragedy:** Kisa Gotami's only son died.
- **The Denial:** Blinded by grief, she carried the dead child to all her neighbors, desperately begging for medicine.
- **The Reaction:** People pitied her but said, She has lost her senses. The boy is dead.
- **The Turning Point:** A man directed her to Sakyamuni, the Buddha, calling him the only physician who could help.

Gemini Notebook

A Strange Prescription

The Request

"Lord and Master, give me the medicine that will cure my boy."

The Condition

Buddha asked for a handful of mustard-seed.

<u>The Catch</u>: It must be taken from a house where no one has lost a child, husband, parent, or friend.

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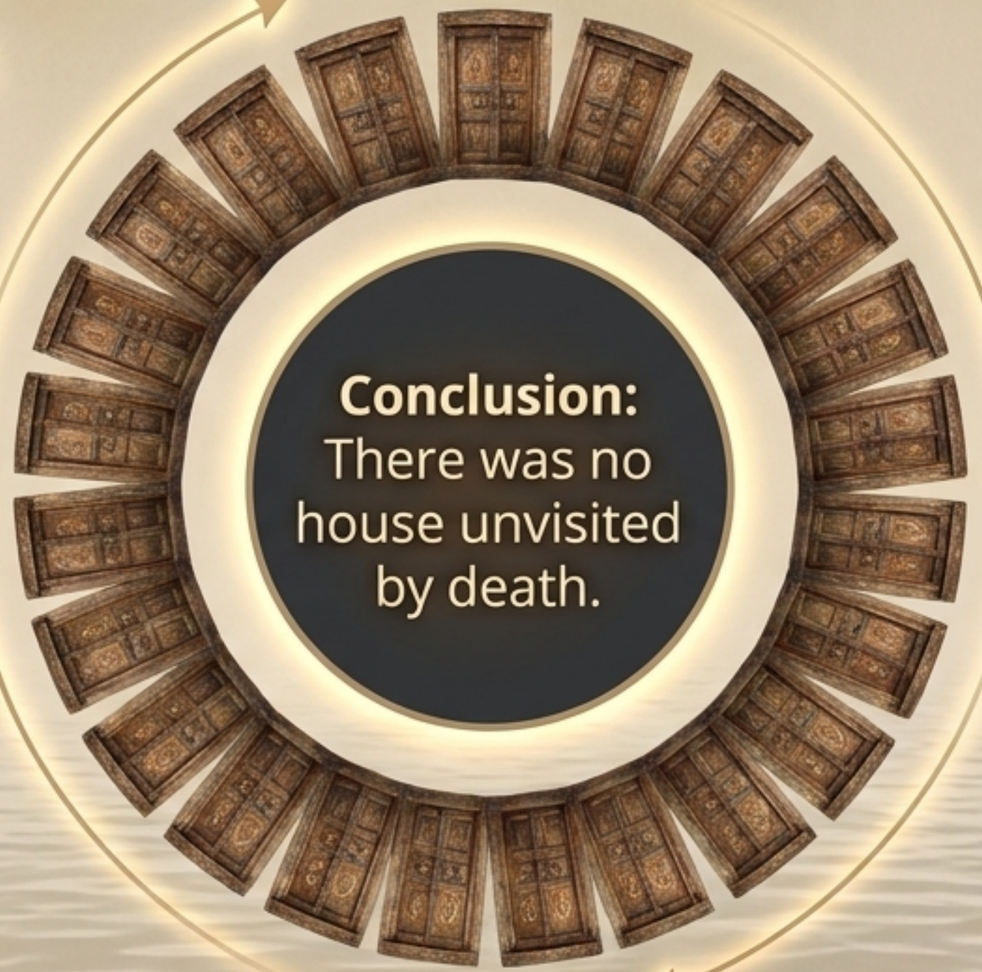
The Universal Truth of Loss

Kisa went from house to house.

People offered the mustard-seed out of pity.

She asked:
Did a beloved one die in your family?

The tragic answer:
Alas! the living are few, but the dead are many. Do not remind us of our deepest grief.



Conclusion:
There was no house unvisited by death.

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The Awakening of Kisa Gotami

Weary and hopeless, Kisa sat by the wayside watching the city lights flicker up and extinguish, realizing human lives follow the exact same fate.

> How selfish am I in my grief!
> Death is common to all.

In this valley of desolation, the only path to immortality is surrendering all selfishness.

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The Core Sermon: Life, Death & Suffering

As ripe fruits are early in danger of falling, so mortals when born are always in danger of death.

As all earthen vessels made by the potter end in being broken, so is the life of mortals.

Key Fact: Young or adult, fool or wise—all fall into the power of death. A father cannot save his son; kinsmen cannot save relatives.

Gemini Notebook

The Arrow of Lamentation

The Futility of Weeping

Weeping and grieving do NOT bring peace. It only makes the body sick and pale. The dead are not saved by it. The world is afflicted with death and decay.

The Path to Peace

He who seeks peace must draw out the arrow of lamentation, complaint, and grief. Only by becoming composed can one become free from sorrow and be blessed.

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Central Themes & Message

Acceptance

Death is inevitable. Accepting this universal truth is the first necessary step toward spiritual healing and overcoming sorrow.

Selfishness in Grief

Extreme grief makes us selfish, blinding us to the fact that others suffer the exact same pain. True healing requires looking outward.

True Peace

He who becomes composed (calm) and extracts the arrow of lamentation will become free from sorrow, and be blessed.

Gemini Notebook

Super Revision: Story Map

1.
The Royal Shield:
Prince Siddhartha lives in luxury for 25 years.

2. The 4 Sights:
Encounters disease, old age, death, and an ascetic.

3.
Enlightenment:
Wanders 7 years; meditates under the Bodhi tree.

4. The First Sermon:
Preaches at Benares on the Ganges.

5.
A Mother's Grief:
Kisa Gotami loses her son; desperately seeks a cure.

6. The Mustard Seed:
Buddha sends her to find a seed from a house with no death.

7.
The Realisation:
Watching flickering lamps, Kisa realizes death is common to all.

8. The Lesson:
Mortals are like ripe fruits/earthen pots. Draw the arrow of grief to find peace.

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Exam Vocabulary Decoder

Inscrutable	Something which cannot be understood or fully explained.
Afflicted with	Affected by suffering, disease, or pain.
Lamentation	The passionate expression of deep sorrow or weeping.
Desolation	A state of complete emptiness, loneliness, or deep sorrow.
Mortals	Beings bound to die (human beings).
Procure	To obtain or get something with care or effort.
Repaired to	Went to (an archaic English stylistic use).
Kinsmen	Blood relations or family members.

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Exam Booster: Master the Answers

Q: Why did Buddha ask Kisa Gotami for a mustard seed specifically?

Ans: To make her realize practically that death is universal. He attached the condition (a house with no death) so she would learn through direct experience, not just words.

Q: How did Kisa Gotami realize she was selfish in her grief?

Ans: Watching city lights flicker and die, she saw human life follows the same fate. She realized she was only thinking of her own loss, forgetting that every home suffers the same pain.

Q: According to Buddha, how can one obtain peace of mind?

Ans: By accepting the world is afflicted with death. One must draw out the arrow of lamentation and stop weeping, as grieving only causes physical sickness and brings no one back.

Gemini Notebook